

Behavior Change Project Instructions

The behavior change paper is based on a goal that each student will set and implement. The topic of the project will include one of the following topics (physical activity, sleep, nutrition, diet, or fluid intake), unless otherwise approved by the instructor.

The project is broken into the following steps:

Step 1: SMART goal and data collection plan– in class, Jan 30th

Step 2: Background research

Step 3: Data Collection – collected February 9th – February 13th

Step 4: Completed Paper – due February 25th

January – February							
Week	Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
3	25	26	27	28	29	30	31
4	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
5	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
6	15	16	17	18	19	20	21
7	22	23	24	25	26	27	28

Step 1: SMART Goal and Data Collection Plan

In class, students will work in groups to create their SMART goals. Next, students will come up with a plan for how they will measure their variables and collect data. Students will submit these plans to the class activity for that day.

SMART Goal

A SMART goal is specific, measurable, attainable, realistic, and timebound. **Be sure to address each aspect of the SMART goal guidelines to receive full credit.**

- State your goal, and explain how it addresses each aim of the SMART Goal design
 - My goal: “I will insure I get 8 hours of sleep every night by going to bed by 11 pm.”
 - Specific: I will get 8 hours of sleep between 11pm and 7 am.
 - Measurable: I will keep a log of when I go to sleep and wake up.
 - Achievable: I typically go to bed at 12:30am, so without 90 minutes of doom scrolling, I will be able to go to sleep by 11pm.
 - Relevant: By sleeping more, I will increase my concentration in class.
 - Timebound: I will follow this plan every night on a daily basis for 1 week.
- **BE VERY SPECIFIC.** If your goal is to reduce sugar, what is your goal number of grams to stay under? If you want to exercise, is there a certain level of intensity necessary to be considered necessary (any activity that involves movement? Heart rate above a

certain level, as measured by your watch?). The more specific you are, the more prepared you will be, and the better the implementation of the plan.

Data Collection Plan

- This section will address how you will collect **and** how you will record data.
- **Be very thorough**
- For planning how you will collect your data...
 - Think about how you will operationally define your task. If your goal is to exercise, what qualifies as “exercise”? Walking? Cardio at the gym? Lifting weights?
 - Use how you define your topic to inform how you will measure the behavior, as that will drastically impact your collection style.
 - For example, if your goal is to reduce sugar intake, and you define “sugar intake” as consuming candy/ bakery items, your collection plan could include...
 - “I will reduce all sugar-based treats from my diet. I will record the number of times I have a sweet treat each day in an excel sheet. In this same excel sheet, I will also track my total number of healthy snacks. For each day, I will calculate a ratio of number of treats to my number of healthy snacks, to track if I am shifting my snacking habits towards healthier options, with less sugar. By shifting towards a healthy snack, I will limit my chance of relapsing and eating sugar when I get hungry.”
 - Alternatively, if you define “sugar intake” as any processed sugar included in all foods
 - “I will reduce all processed sugar in my diet. I will record the grams of sugar in every meal I eat. To facilitate this, I will use the app ‘MyNetDiary’ to calculate how much sugar is in each meal, then keep a log of each meal’s sugar consumption in an excel sheet. By increasing my awareness of the amount of sugar in the meals I consume regularly, I will be able to make more informed dietary choices moving forward. This knowledge will help me maintain a diet with a limited amount of sugar.”
- For planning how you will record your day...
 - Consider things like what apps and formats will be most helpful. Will you need a table? A list with a value per day? What information will you collect each day?
 - For example, if you are recording your diet, one approach would be to use a table, where you have a column for each, a row for each meal, and in each cell, you record your total sugar intake.
 - Alternatively, you could record your diet using a series of lists in a Word document, where you have a heading for every day, with bullet points for each food item you ate that day listed.

Step 2: Background Research

In this stage, you will conduct background research on your topic. This section needs to be based on at least THREE peer reviewed articles. If you are unsure how to access peer-reviewed journal articles through the UNK library database, or if you need a refresher on where to get information for citing your sources, please see the “Accessing Journal Articles” document in the Behavior Change Paper module on Canvas. Each article used must have an in-text citation and a listing in the references. For information on writing up the background research, please see the instructions for the background section of the paper. For information on citing your sources, please see the instructions for the references section of the paper.

Note: If during the background research process, you decide to adjust your SMART goal or data collection plan, you MUST get approval from the instructor by the Friday before beginning data collection.

Step 3: Data Collection

For one week, you will follow your data collection plan, keeping thorough record of your ability to maintain your behavior change. If you deviate from the plan (ex: twisting an ankle and being unable to workout), it is important to make note of what changed and why.

Step 4: Behavior Change Paper

The final paper will provide an overview of the entire project. It will include 1) a summary of the research on the health behavior and why it is important to the student (~1 page), 2) a description of the goal and how it meets SMART guidelines (0.5 pages), 3) an explanation of the data collection plan and the resulting behavior data (0.5-1 page), 4) AI feedback and discussion (0.5-1 page), 5) a project reflection (0.5 pages), 6) APA references (as long as needed), and appendices (2 pages). The paper should be written in Times New Roman, 12-point font, and double-spaced. There should be separate pages for the cover page, references, Appendix A, and Appendix B. A template will be provided, so students can edit directly into the document, without needing to change the formatting.

The Background Section (20 points)

The first paragraph in the background section should be a review of AT LEAST three peer-reviewed articles. Each article referenced must have an in-text citation and a listing in the references. Be thorough in providing sources for your information, illustrating that your points are based on science and not opinion (yes, you will likely have a citation for 80% of your sentences in this section). This section should be written in the student’s own words, with NO direct quotes. Throughout this paragraph, it should be clear that changing the behavior is directly related to shaping health outcomes, and is not just a change made by chance.

The second paragraph will explain why you were interested in making the behavior change. This section will answer the question, “Why did you choose this behavior to change?” You may want to address things like direct impact to daily life, family history, or reaching specific goals.

A note on in-text citations for this section:

- In APA, there are two forms of in-text citation: narrative and parenthetical
 - Narrative: When the in-text citation is used in the sentence
 - Example: Scheuler (2025) established that health psychology is a great field by ...
 - Parenthetical: When the sentence does not mention the source, the citation is listed at the end of the sentence that references the material.
 - Example: Health psychology is a crucial field (Scheuler, 2025).
- There are slight variations in citation structure based on number of authors, but in each case, the in-text citation will include the author information and the date published
 - One author:
 - Narrative: Scheuler (2025)
 - Parenthetical: (Scheuler, 2025)
 - Two authors:
 - Narrative: Scheuler and Turner (2025)
 - Parenthetical: (Scheuler & Turner, 2025)
 - Three or more authors:
 - Narrative: Scheuler et al. (2025) OR Scheuler and colleagues (2025) [or other variations on colleagues/ fellow researchers/ associates/ etc.]
 - Parenthetical: (Scheuler et al., 2025)
- For more on in-text citations, see: <https://apastyle.apa.org/style-grammar-guidelines/citations>

SMART Goal (10 points)

This section should be at least one paragraph (all complete sentences), explicitly stating your goal, and describing how that goal meets SMART guidelines. Be sure that you address EACH of the five guidelines separately.

Collection Summary (15 points)

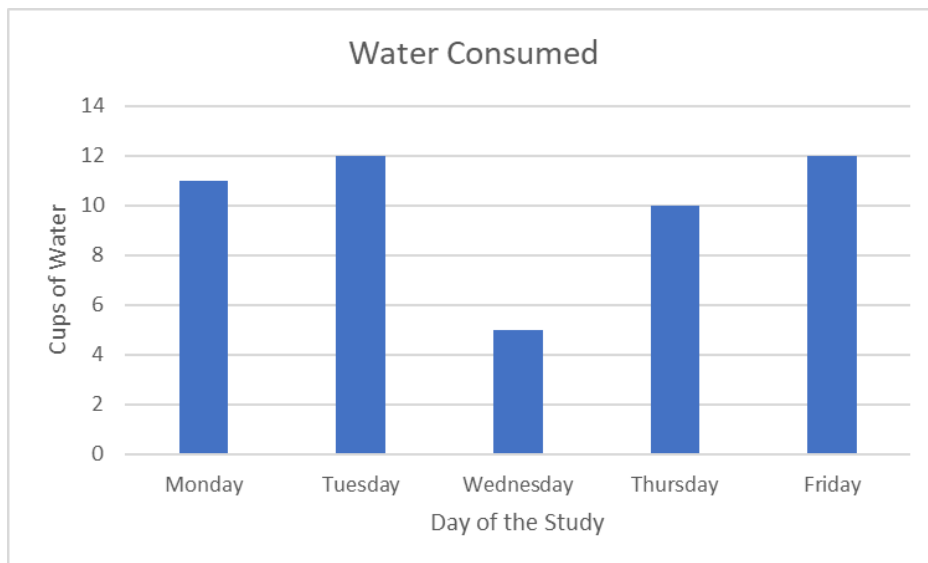
In this section, you will explain how you collected your data. How did you measure your health behavior? What are all the aspects you measured? How did you collect your data? What were the results of your behavior change? This section be at least one paragraph, and explain your data in sentence form. Do not forget to include units for your behavior (cups for water, hours for sleep, etc.). Additionally, you will include a table or figure depicting your results. When including the table/ figure, it will have a table/ figure number (most likely only “1”, unless you are using two figures/tables) and a table/ figure title. Be sure to reference this table/ figure

within the body of the text. Note: if your table/ figure is too big to fit on the page, leave the gap between the title and the image. See below for an example:

As seen in Figure 1, there was a notable drop in the amount of water I consumed in the middle of the week. This drop in water consumption may be explained by the exam I took in the middle of the week, as I was drinking coffee instead of water.

Figure 1

The Water Consumed Throughout the Week



AI Feedback (15 points)

For this section, you will request feedback from a generative AI platform such as Copilot or ChatGPT. You will include the prompt you enter into the platform in Appendix A, then copy the response in Appendix B. Then, in this section, you will summarize the feedback the platform suggested **IN YOUR OWN WORDS**. After briefly describing the feedback, you will address if you believe that you could implement the suggestions, and if they would improve your success. The feedback summary and implementation response should be one to two paragraphs long. Be sure to use in-text citations when referencing the platform, and reference the appendices (just like we do for a table or figure). See below for an example:

To determine ways to improve my behavior change, I provided ChatGPT with a description of my approach, and requested feedback (please see Appendix A for the prompt I provided and Appendix B for the ChatGPT response). ChatGPT (2025) provided a multitude of suggestions. One suggestion was that I implement a reward system for my water consumption, where I get to buy one book (of \$25 value) for each week that I meet my water consumption goals (ChatGPT, 2025). As I am quite determined to create a library that will rival the library depicted in Disney's 1991 movie, *Beauty and the Beast*, this reward system would be highly

motivating. Thus, if I were to continue this behavior change, I would likely implement this suggestion. An additional suggestion that ChatGPT (2025) provided was...

As a note, you can read more about the guidelines on APA citation at the following link:
<https://apastyle.apa.org/blog/cite-generative-ai-references>

Project Reflection (10 points)

In this section, you will reflect on the entire project, addressing each of the following questions. What aspects led to the overall success (or lack thereof) of your behavior change? What would you do differently to make this behavior change into a health habit? (Note: consider things like modifying your goal, adjust how you measured the behavior, or implementing a different reward system). What did you learn about yourself and/ or the health behavior?

APA References (10 points)

The reference list should include ALL sources references in the paper, in alphabetical order and hanging indent format. Each source in a reference list should include information about the author, date, article title, journal information, pages (or Article ID), and DOI. Each section of a reference has specific formatting rules, and is listed in a specific order.

- Authors: Last Name, Initials; not italicized; in order provided in original paper
 - Scheuler, B. L.
 - Scheuler, B. L & Turner, R.
 - Scheuler, B. L, Turner, R. & Bartholomay, E.
 - This process is repeated for up to 21 authors (after that, there are extra rules. See Dr. Scheuler for help in this case)
- Date: year listed in parentheses, followed by a period.
 - (2025)
- Article Title: Write full title, only capitalizing proper nouns or word that begin a sentence/ sentence fragment; not italicized; end with a period
 - The benefits of health psychology: A comprehensive review.
- Journal Title: Beginning letter of each word capitalized; italicized; separated from volume/ issue information with a comma
 - *The Health Psychology Bulletin,*
- Volume and Issue: Volume number is italicized; issue number is not italicized, but is placed in parentheses; use a comma to separate from page numbers (next element); note: there is no space between the volume and parentheses
 - 25(12),
- Page numbers: Write page range with a dash in between numbers; not italicized; end with a period.
 - 12-27.

- Note- some online articles will have an article ID instead of page numbers. In that case, where page numbers would go, you will write “Article” and the ID number
 - Article 23456
- DOI: DOI included as hyperlink (will contain the entire URL)
 - Scheuler, B. L.

All this information is listed back-to-back for each source. Altogether, it will look like:

Rybackowska, M., & Sparks, L. (2022). Ageing consumers and e-commerce activities. *Ageing and Society*, 42(8), 1879–1898. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0144686X20001932>

If you need help with formatting your references, please email Dr. Scheuler promptly, to schedule a time to walk through formatting fixes. To help, you can also edit your information into the following examples:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here*, #(#), #–#. (replace this line with DOI link)

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here*, #(#), #–#. (replace this line with DOI link)

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here*, #(#), #–#. (replace this line with DOI link)

OR, if the article has an ID instead of page numbers:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here*, #(#), Article #. (replace this line with DOI link)

And for your AI source, you can edit this citation:

ChatGPT. (2025, September 28). *Citing ChatGPT in APA for beginners* [generative AI chat].

ChatGPT. <https://chatgpt.com/c/68da0b8e-bfbc-8321-a026-825dcc2ee250>

Writing

The entire paper should be in black ink, Times New Roman 12-point font, double spaced. Indent new paragraphs. Paragraphs should be three to eight sentences. Do NOT add extra spaces between paragraphs. Use full sentences and in-text citations. Please check thoroughly for grammatical errors and unclear sentences.

Policies

AI Use

The use of AI platforms is only permitted for the feedback section. AI should not be used for any resources, information, planning, or explanation aspect of the project.

Late Policy

As per the syllabus, there will be a 10-point deduction for every day late. As students are aware of their paper for a month, and the paper is submitted online, extensions will not be granted based on events that occur the day the paper is due.